

WC 2026 Youth Training Report

Where were the starting XI players trained between ages 5 and 16?

Data through 75 completed matches · July 5, 2026

Completed matches	Unique starters	Unique training countries	Unique training clubs
75	754	53	995

Top 20 Training Countries

Unique starters counts each player once for every country where they trained, regardless of how long they spent there.

Weighted starters allocates each player as a fraction across countries in proportion to the years they spent training there between ages 5 and 16 — for example, a player who trained 8 years in France and 4 years in Spain contributes 0.67 to France and 0.33 to Spain. See Appendix 1 for the full counting rule.

#	Country	Unique starters	Weighted starters
1	France	70	58.92
2	England	50	36.60
3	Netherlands	47	39.21
4	Germany	39	28.23
5	Spain	37	27.43
6	United States	30	20.63
7	Belgium	28	22.82
8	Argentina	25	19.28
9	Norway	22	17.24
10	Portugal	22	16.84
11	Sweden	21	15.73
12	Austria	19	17.17
13	Brazil	18	15.12
14	Czechia	18	14.50
15	Switzerland	17	15.94
16	Japan	17	15.38
17	Uzbekistan	17	6.00
18	Australia	16	13.96
19	Mexico	16	12.00
20	Paraguay	16	10.32

Top 20 Training Clubs

Same year-share method as above, applied at club level. Players who moved between clubs are split across each club in proportion to time spent there.

#	Club	Country	Unique starters	Weighted starters
1	Anderlecht	Belgium	10	6.22
2	Paris Saint-Germain	France	10	4.51
3	Barcelona	Spain	10	4.48
4	Ajax	Netherlands	9	5.74
5	PSV	Netherlands	8	5.09
6	Independiente del Valle	Ecuador	8	4.10
7	Manchester City	England	8	3.73
8	Bayern Munich	Germany	7	4.04
9	Dinamo Zagreb	Croatia	7	3.69
10	Benfica	Portugal	7	3.45
11	Genk	Belgium	7	1.57
12	Fulham	England	6	3.92
13	Chelsea	England	6	3.83
14	Rennes	France	6	3.45
15	Lyon	France	6	3.06
16	Cerro Porteño	Paraguay	6	2.49
17	Al Ahly	Egypt	5	4.00
18	Manchester United	England	5	3.16
19	Hajduk Split	Croatia	5	3.04
20	Boca Juniors	Argentina	5	3.00

Local-Trained Ratio by National Team

Percentage of each team's tracked starters classified as locally trained. A player is locally trained if they have fewer than 5 foreign-country years on record. For players with no year data, they are counted as locally trained if any of their clubs is in the home country. Sorted from highest to lowest.

National team	Tracked starters	Locally trained	Local ratio
Czechia	18	18	100%
Australia	17	17	100%
England	17	17	100%
Uzbekistan	17	17	100%
South Africa	16	16	100%
Switzerland	16	16	100%
Austria	15	15	100%
Brazil	15	15	100%
Egypt	15	15	100%
Saudi Arabia	15	15	100%
Jordan	14	14	100%
Portugal	14	14	100%
Sweden	14	14	100%
Netherlands	13	13	100%
Uruguay	13	13	100%
Norway	21	20	95%
Belgium	17	16	94%
Japan	17	16	94%
Spain	16	15	94%
IR Iran	15	14	93%
Colombia	14	13	93%
Korea Republic	14	13	93%
Ecuador	13	12	92%
New Zealand	13	12	92%
Argentina	21	19	90%
Canada	17	15	88%
Mexico	17	15	88%
Scotland	16	14	88%
France	15	13	87%

Panama	15	13	87%
USA	21	18	86%
Germany	13	11	85%
Croatia	16	13	81%
Paraguay	16	13	81%
Côte d'Ivoire	15	11	73%
Qatar	15	11	73%
Ghana	16	11	69%
Haiti	14	9	64%
Iraq	16	10	62%
Senegal	16	10	62%
Cabo Verde	18	11	61%
Türkiye	18	11	61%
Bosnia and Herzegovina	16	9	56%
Tunisia	16	9	56%
Algeria	16	6	38%
Morocco	15	4	27%
DR Congo	14	3	21%
Curaçao	13	2	15%

Appendix 1 — Data Conditions and Counting Rules

Data sources

- **Starting XIs:** Wikipedia 2026 FIFA World Cup group and knockout-stage pages. Each starting-XI row is linked to its match section URL.
- **Youth-club histories:** Wikipedia player infobox 'Youth career' section, fetched per player. Year spans and club names are parsed directly from the infobox table.
- **Club countries:** Inferred from each linked club's Wikipedia page lead text and categories using phrase-pattern matching.

Age window

Only training that overlaps the age range 5–16 is included. If a Wikipedia source gives a spell of 2008–2015 for a player born in 2000, that is converted to ages 8–15 and clipped to the 5–16 window.

Counting rule for players who moved

Each player's contribution is split across clubs and countries in proportion to the number of years they spent at each during ages 5–16. For example, a player who trained 8 years in France and 4 years in Spain contributes 0.67 to France and 0.33 to Spain. Where no year data is available, an equal split across clubs is used as a fallback.

Confidence tiers

- **Medium:** year span extracted from Wikipedia infobox; age estimates calculated from the player's birth year.
- **Low (fallback):** only a club name was available with no year span. The club is counted in unique starters but contributes 0 to weighted starters.

Known limitations

- The tournament was still in progress on the data collection date (2026-07-05). Knockout matches from the Round of 16 onwards are partially included.
- Club-country assignment is automated and may misclassify youth academies with ambiguous Wikipedia pages.
- Multi-country starters (91) are split across countries; multi-club starters (372) are split across clubs.

Source data

Collected data for this report can be found at: github.com/lorihe/WC2026-youth-clubs/tree/main/data